

ANI

AVINASH SABLE, 29 >

***Steeplechase** 3,000m*

What do you call an athlete who beats his personal best—and the national record—in every second race? Sable, Avinash Sable. Son of a farmer from Beed in Maharashtra, Sable made headlines when he broke the 37-year-old national record in steeplechase back in 2018. Since then, he has slashed 20 seconds off it, with the recent one coming on July 7 at the Paris Diamond League where he finished sixth in a top-notch field with a time of eight minutes and 9.91 seconds. His declaration in Jio Cinema's *The Dreamers* is simple: "*Mera competition sirf meri timing se hai* (My competition is with my own timing)". In a discipline dominated by African nations like Kenya, Ethiopia and Morocco, Sable has shaken up the field as an Asian who can match them lap for lap and obstacle for obstacle. He lived up to the hype when he won silver at the Commonwealth Games in 2022, ending Kenyan domination, followed by gold at the Asian Games last year. In a race of endurance, time weighs heavily on the subedar in the Indian Army. His ultimate aim: clock a sub-8-minute run. If he does manage that in Paris, a podium finish is a definite possibility. ■



AFP

SARABJOT SINGH, 22 >

***Shooting** 10m Air Pistol*

Sarabjot's breakthrough came at the 2023 Hangzou Asian Games when he clinched the team gold in the 10-metre air pistol event, defeating the rampant Chinese. At the same Games, he won silver in the mixed team event with Divya T.S. Sarabjot's star has risen ever since and his gun sights are fixed on the Paris Olympics. Earlier, in 2023, Singh had blasted his way to the 10m air pistol gold at the Bhopal ISSF World Cup and later at Baku, where he won the air pistol mixed team gold at yet another ISSF World Cup. But the greatest fillip to his Olympic dreams came last month, when he won gold at his favourite event at the ISSF World Cup in Munich. Born in a family of farmers in Haryana, Sarabjot took up shooting in school. "In 2012-13, we moved Sarabjot to Bhagirath Public School in Ambala where the management stressed on sports. I wanted him to take up volleyball, but the chairman insisted he take up shooting," says Sarabjot's father, Jitender Singh. "There has been no looking back after it." ■



AP

–Rahul Noronha